

► Witches' war

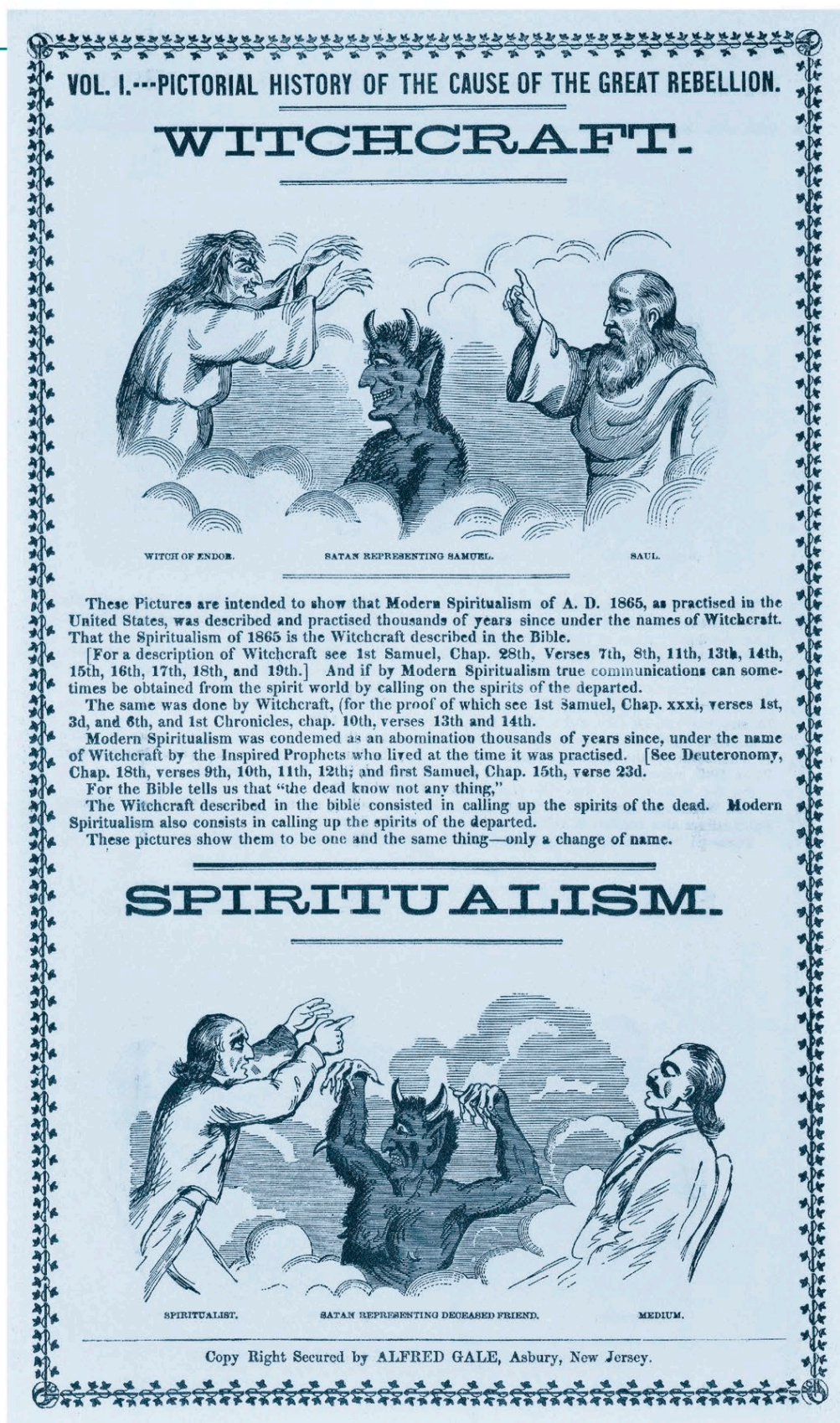
Detractors of spiritualism often equated it with witchcraft. This 19th-century image, complete with the Witch of Endor and Satan, defines spiritualism as another form of the witchcraft condemned in the Bible, and cites it as a cause of the Great Rebellion (the American Civil War).

Fraud, heresy, and reform

The lure of money and fame led to numerous instances of outrageous fraud, and some spiritualist practitioners were prosecuted. In 1869, William Mumler, an American "spirit photographer," underwent a sensational fraud trial. He was acquitted on lack of evidence, but his spiritualist career was virtually destroyed. Seven years later in England, American medium Henry Slade was also tried for fraud—and found guilty. His "spirit messages," which seemed to appear on slates, were revealed to have been written with his toes.

In 1887, the University of Pennsylvania's Seybert Commission for Investigating Modern Spiritualism produced a report that was generally negative about spiritualistic practice. The views of organized Christian religion, both Protestant and Catholic, were also largely negative. A Catholic edict of 1898 condemned spiritualism, and many Church figures equated it with witchcraft and necromancy.

However, Nonconformists and Quakers forged connections with spiritualism, as did the reform movements for women's suffrage and the abolition of slavery. Pascal Beverly Randolph, an American spiritualist and Rosicrucian, was an abolitionist, and American spiritualist Achsa W. Sprague advocated for both abolition and women's rights. Spiritualists valued traits such as intuition and sensitivity—considered feminine in the 19th century—but claiming to channel spirits let female practitioners express views that could otherwise have been dismissed as inappropriate. Many women pursued careers as mediums, probably also drawn by the opportunities for travel, adventure, and fame.



“Oh the road to En-dor is the oldest road
And the craziest road of all!”

RUDYARD KIPLING ON SPIRITUALISM, FROM HIS POEM “EN-DOR”, 1919